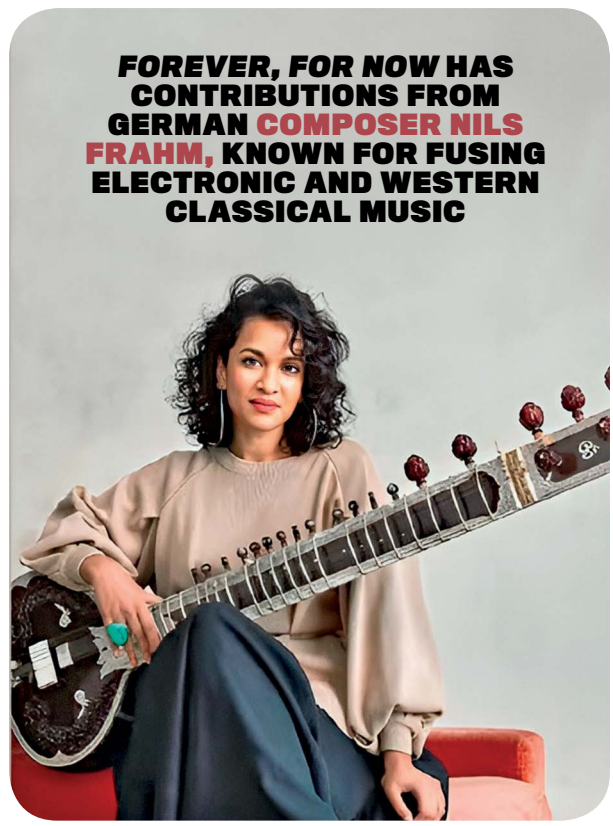
Almost 20 years after the release of her debut album as a composer, *Rise in* 2005, sitar player Anoushka Shankar feels people finally get it. "The change I've noticed in the last few years has been quite humbling in the way people call out certain songs at my shows," she says. "Whereas at the beginning, I had to carve out an area for the type of genre-free music I was making, where I could feel the splits in the audience where some were coming for my classical work, and some were coming for the electronic sound. Now there's a core listener group that really knows what I do."

While her compositions can't be called "pure classical music", there's no doubt that just like her father, the legendary Ravi Shankar, she has helped introduce the sitar to listeners around the world. "I'm like the gateway," she says. "This is going to sound so stupid but at some point last year, I was sitting with my mom and the penny dropped about the word 'culture' and how things like yoghurt and other food items need a 'mother culture'. And I was like, that's exactly what I keep trying to explain, that no legacy, no culture ever stays frozen, it's always imbibing what that new artist, new generation is bringing in while standing on the shoulders of everything that came before it."

It's precisely Shankar's ability to seamlessly blend traditional and modern styles—her compositions have merged Indian classical music with electronic music, jazz and flamenco, to name just a few—that has resulted in her being among the rare artists to play both venues that mostly host classical musicians and a multi-genre popular music festival like Lollapalooza India. The festival, being held on January 27 and 28 in Mumbai, is part of her 2024 India tour, which includes stand-alone concerts in Bengaluru, Hyderabad, Pune and Delhi (from January 22 to 31).

At those gigs, we can expect to hear tracks from her October 2023 release *Chapter I: Forever, For Now*, the first in a trilogy of mini-albums she has planned. Shankar chose to focus on a few songs at a time because she found it "creatively freeing". She says, "I was getting a bit in my own head about what the next album was going to be and what it was going to say." The EPs will instead draw on multiple themes with a common thread running through. The title track of *Forever, For Now*, for instance, was inspired by an afternoon in her garden when one of her sons fell asleep on her lap while she was playing the sitar. "There was a glimpse of sunlight through leaves, and a moment of peace, of tenderness. I had this profound realisation of how big the small moments can be."

FOREVER, FOR NOW HAS CONTRIBUTIONS FROM GERMAN COMPOSER NILS FRAHM, KNOWN FOR FUSING ELECTRONIC AND WESTERN CLASSICAL MUSIC



Chapter II will go "even more into a place of peace and healing", says Shankar. "For me, it's about a night, and some kind of solace or regeneration that a person may need from the music. All I know about *Chapter III*, which I've just begun, is that I want it to feel like you've come through something and now you're out in the blazing heat of like an Indian sunrise, and that the music will be very hypnotic, mystic and more energetic than the first two."

Each mini-album will feature a different set of featured artists. *Forever, For Now* includes contributions from German composer Nils Frahm, who is known for bringing together electronic and western classical music, and on whose label